

PANKAJ TIWARI



Going Cattle Class

BHOPAL Ever since Uma Bharati became chief minister in 2003, bovines have never had it so good in Madhya Pradesh. The ochre-robed BJP rebel was known to feed cows on her way to office during her tenure. Well the cows haven't had reason to fret even after her departure since the present chief minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan is also going strong on the cattle front.

The ritual celebration of Govardhan Puja, a day after Diwali, turned into a

spectacle of bovine bonanza in the state capital with Chauhan and octogenarian Governor Balram Jhakhar witnessing a catwalk of cows in full festival regalia at the open-air theatre in Ravindra Bhavan. Scores of cows and pairs of oxen from different parts of the state converged at the venue for the showpiece 'bovine beauty pageant'. Three cattle shelters, one of them from Bhopal Central Jail, were rewarded for the most

COW HERD: The bovine beauty pageant fetching cows. Besides, three farmers were each rewarded for rearing the most robust pairs of oxen.

While their politics may be poles apart, Chauhan and Jhakhar—who had a torrid relationship in the beginning but patched up later—do not fight shy in claiming the mantle of son-of-the-soil when the occasion demands.

Sharing the dais with Chauhan and the Shankaracharya of Ramchandra-puram Math, Swami Radheshwar Bharati, Jhakhar directed the state Government to improve the condition of cattle shelters and prevent their culling. For Jhakhar, who stands well over six feet in his socks, the secret of his towering personality, by his own admission, is five litres of cow milk that he used to have everyday as in his childhood. Chauhan announced additional allocation for feeding stray cattle in shelters.

A cattle bonanza or Chauhan's own version of the "holy cow" politics?

by Ambresh Mishra

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: K.C. Ibrahim, 88, who played four Test matches and first class cricket. He was the oldest Test cricketer who made his international debut in 1948 on the West Indies tour.

DIED: Vijay Kumar Khandelwal, 71, four-time Lok Sabha



member of BJP from Betul constituency. He was also treasurer of the BJP's

Madhya Pradesh unit.

CONFERRED: On Sudha Mahalingam, the first K. Subrahmanyam Award for excellence in strategic studies, by Vice-President Hamid Ansari.

QUIT: S.C. Mishra, minister without portfolio, from the Mayawati Government in Uttar Pradesh.

QUALIFIED: The Indian U-16 team, for the Asian Football Confederation finals in Dammam, Saudi Arabia. They beat higher ranked teams Lebanon and hosts Saudi Arabia.

VIS-A-VIS PRAKASH KARAT CPI(M) general secretary **versus** MAMATA BANERJEE Trinamool Congress chief

Trinamool Congress has taken the help of Maoists to consolidate their hold in the area. Maoists are running a parallel raj there.



SAURABH SINGH

Those who had gone to Nepal and themselves talked to Maoists are now shouting about the Maoists in Nandigram.

EPILOGUE: Will somebody talk about the missing state Government too?